

‘Emotional spending is perfectly normal to a degree, however it can become a “fall back” for trying to get rid of difficult emotions and only serves to create more stress in the long run. Online shopping is a particularly easy way to spend without considering the consequences because it can feel less real and delayed payment options may give a false sense of security.’

Understanding *why* we make seemingly illogical choices when it comes to spending, and why our emotions hold such sway over something that should, in many ways, be a simple maths decision, can be really helpful in creating a change in our behaviour. Appreciating the way that my brain was working at times when I was drawn to online shopping helped me to recognize that making very quick spending decisions, or feeling a pressing urge to buy expensive items, usually meant that there was something else going on, and I learned to use this feeling as a prompt to explore and interrogate those feelings, rather than succumbing to the urge (most of the time).

Now is the time to start looking at the circumstances under which you tend to shop according to impulse rather than need, and decipher why and how you end up making spending decisions that you later regret, or that you can’t afford. For most of us, there will be certain triggers or series of events that lead us to seek the temporary high of an order confirmation email or the steady chug of a receipt printing behind the counter. For example, does your impulse spending tend to happen in the evening, when you’re bored, anxious or lonely? Often, in the past, when I was left alone with my thoughts, or